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Indian Americans have become more influential across industries: (L-R) Journalist Fareed Zakaria, New York mayor Zohran Mamdani, former U.S. vice-president Kamala Harris, Google CEO Sundar Pichai, former PepsiCo CEO Indra Nooyi, astronaut Sunita Williams, comedian Hasan Minhaj and Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella. (GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK)



AMERICA AT
250
THE DIASPORA AT
A CROSSROADS

Meenakshi N. Ahamed

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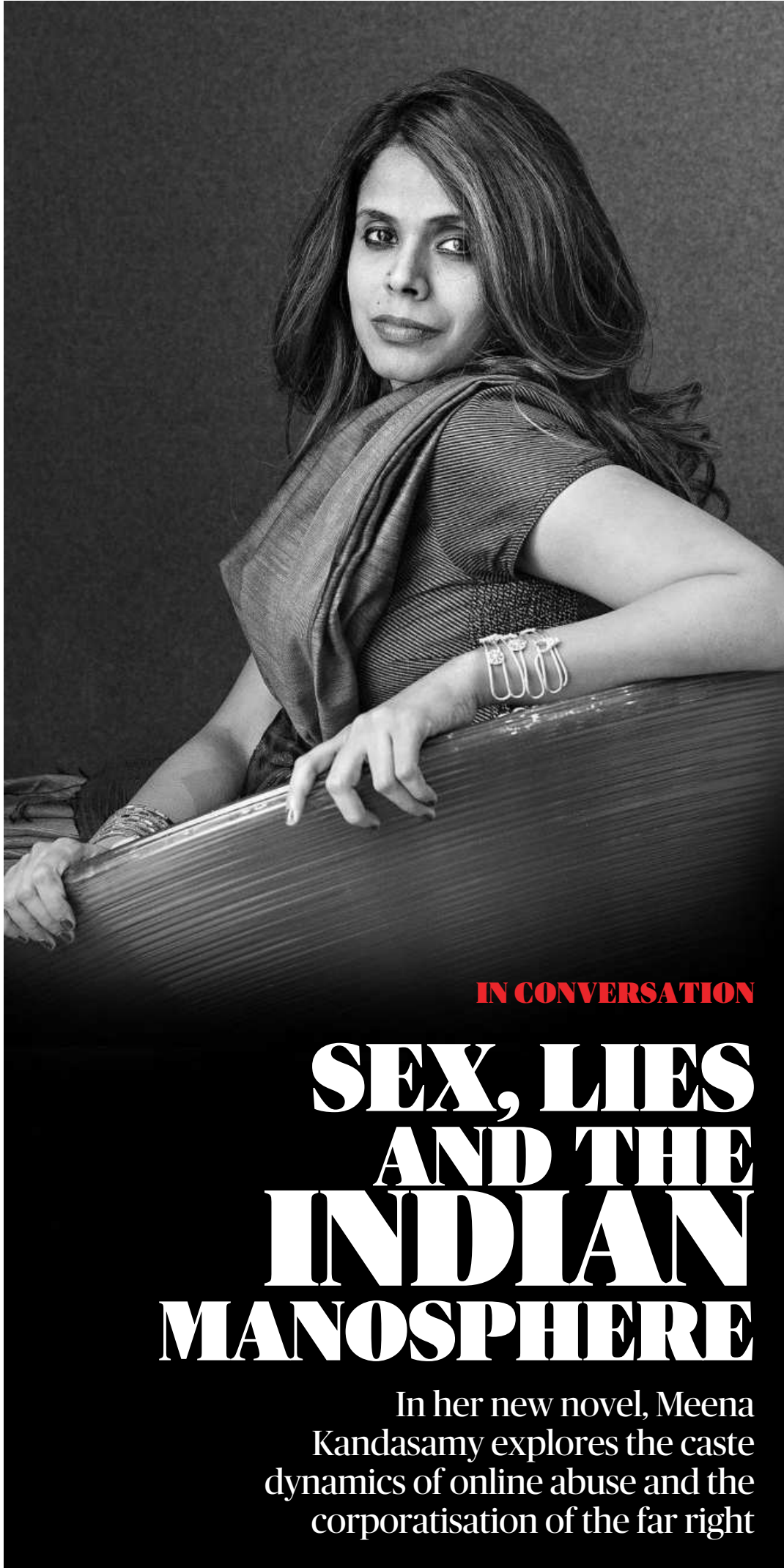
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▲ Poet and author Meena Kandasamy.

knew you wanted to write? When did you start working on it?

A: I started in 2020. The idea came from different events. One, there was this fake online auction of Muslim women just because they were outspoken. Second, we saw more and more morphed videos and photos emerging. The question of what happens to women's selfies, their intimate pictures, what women take in a moment of trust and share, and the fallout of it, is huge. Third, the Pollachi case disturbed me. It was a cycle: women would be abused, have intimate pictures taken, and then they would be called and blackmailed and subjected to more brutality, and that too would be videographed. The fact that one image can do that to a woman's life left a deep impact on me.

Q: We experience Amy's anger, heartbreak, rebellion. She's not an easy character to read and live with. What is it like to be in the head of such a character?

A: It came from something trivial and something profound. The trivial part is that I cannot do anything that I find boring. A novel takes 4-5 years, and with motherhood, even longer. The reader exists, but the first person who has to be interested in it, find it engaging, and find drama in it, is me.

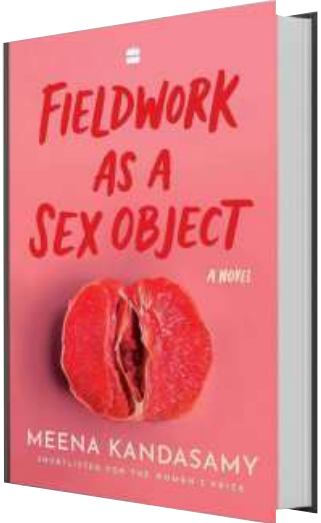
The more profound reason why it (the character) had to be someone entirely different from me is because of something I have understood as an activist: we cannot become selective in our solidarity. We cannot say our solidarity will extend only to people we like. People may be annoying, they may be vain, but if an injustice is being done to them, you have to stand up for them.

Q: Amy's mother is the opposite of the trope we often see in Indian novels. The minute a daughter is in this kind of trouble, parents tend to be furious, disown her, and so on. But, here, we have a mother with a sense of humour and a lot of spunk. How did you shape this character?

A: We have foreclosed the idea that our parents evolve. It is very tragic. We try to engage our children and teach them how to see the world. We believe that work can be done on the young but we don't somehow believe that work can be done on old people. The most remarkable people I have seen are my parents. They have navigated a lot of distance from where they started, but also the kind of opinions they would hold on to, say, around sexuality. There is so much room for them to evolve and become other versions of themselves.

We also blame mothers for projecting their dreams and ambitions onto us, but a lot of them want us simply to be free. Indian mothers cannot tell us this in public, but they do ask us, in many ways, to live our lives in ways denied to them.

This was what was running through my head when I wrote Amy's mother. Also, with both the mother and daughter in the book, I wanted to show that they enjoy a lot of privileges, but they are also controlled and are victims in many ways.



Radhika Santhanam
radhika.s@thehindu.co.in

Poet and writer Meena Kandasamy centres her new novel, *Fieldwork As a Sex Object* (HarperCollins), around a London-based upper-caste Marxist student from India, who wakes up one morning to find that she is the subject of a deepfake video. Amrita Chaturvedi (Amy, in her London circles) is unapologetically sexually active, but the woman in the video is not her. Overnight, she becomes a trending hashtag and the target of relentless, vile online abuse.

Amy tries to stem the hysteria with the help of her friends – a Dalit woman, Nirmala or Nimmi; a white woman, India; and India's boyfriend, Child Soldier – while her mother keeps calling to check on her and navigates a prying family. A blistering exploration of misogyny, political extremism, and the Indian manosphere, the novel is written in Kandasamy's

characteristic style, pulling no punches and laced with humour. Edited excerpts from an interview:

Question: *The manosphere is a prominent theme in the book. What do you think makes the Indian manosphere particularly unique when compared to the West?*

Answer: The Indian manosphere has an enormous amount of caste superiority built into its DNA. I have been subjected to a lot of online abuse for 14-15 years. It's not just about the fact that I am a woman, or I'm outspoken, or what my politics are; it finally boils down to caste.

We also tend to import all our theories from the West in a cookie-cutter model to try and understand ourselves. That may be problematic. For instance, the Western understanding of an incel is someone who doesn't have sex, who is deprived of it. But the idea of the isolated individual as an incel is very much a Western construct, and I don't necessarily think the Indian manosphere is dominated by

incels – many of them might be married or have relationships in their lives.

The Indian manosphere, especially within the far right, has become a very corporate model. Here, it is a political project. It was cultivated to occupy public discourse online. We just cannot flatten it or be reductive about it.

Q: *Given your years of speaking out online and the abuse you've faced, was this a story you always*

When hope takes wing

This anthology of global poetry celebrates shared humanity beyond conflict and prejudice

Malashri Lal

Abindranath Tagore's song 'Pagla Hawa' seems to hover over Mitali Chakravarty's anthology of poems, *Wild Winds*, selected from the journal she edits, *Borderless*. This exquisite collection of verses by 25 writers from around the world shares the theme of liberation from earthly bondage and endorses the individual's deeper connection with a cosmic wholeness.

If, like the wild wind, each person could dance to the rhythm of their soul, would not this troubled planet heal? The poets here are 'ideators' offering compelling perspectives on the challenges that drag humankind into desolation.

If the wind is wild (*pagla* in Bengali), the 'Birds in Flight' (poem by A. Jessie Michael) are synchronised in perfect formation/ inbuilt navigation. Such buoyant poetry uplifts the spirit despite the damnation of war, the 'flotsam' of refugees, and the callousness of leaders.

The 'keynote' to the book is, interestingly, the last poem in the collection – a deliberate placement as the enduring message of *Wild Winds*. Chakravarty's powerful poem, titled 'Phenomenon', dedicated to American poet and activist Maya Angelou, states an essential truth about *every/ human as a miracle*. The refrain *I am a phenomenon*, echoes Angelou's famous poem 'Phenomenal Woman'.

On common ground

Mitali strides further in listing personal traumas such as cancer and abuse, and discriminatory social practices, including gender inequity, racism and patriarchy. She goes beyond feminism to speak of a universal humanism and the poem concludes with the lyrical chorus: *I am you/ You are me. We are/ Borderless Beyond all/ Horizons, we shine*.

The sky remains the protagonist, and John Swain writes: *I recite the codex pouring from your mirrored eye stone,/ we read the light in silence, awed by the light, your table*.

Another graphic poem called 'Murmuration' refers to a spectacular formation when thousands of starlings fly in swirling patterns. Poet Jared Carter reads this as a pathway to eternity cast into an image: *...These are/ the magi, drawn/ to ancient practice, journeyed far,/ still moving on*.

A rare poem from the Balochi language, 'Jungle' (by Munir Momin, translated by Fazal Baloch), asks whether the terror is within us or outside: *Such terror stirs within,/ none dare to face themselves./ The road runs deep with fear*.

The above examples highlight another achievement of the book – that the poetry is in original English as well as in translation, thereby erasing the artificial divide among languages that has created unfortunate hierarchies. By cutting through cultures,

religions, languages, race, gender and authority, Chakravarty places all human beings on the same precarious platform of self-identification.

Confluence of ideas

It is surprising and also delightful to see humour and wordplay in a few poems. Rhys Hughes will appeal to many urbanites caught in traffic jams or munching out of biscuit tins. With a chuckle, he ends a poem on stranded vehicles with the lines: *That's right./ Every night before bed/ I eat traffic jam./ Instead of drinking cocoa*.

This unusual anthology is so realistic in portraying our devastated land, yet so adept in proposing ways of addressing correctives. A borderless world may seem like a utopian dream but when world leaders establish coalitions by crossing borders, is that not a compelled dissolving of man-made boundaries? Yet, ordinary people are citizens or refugees depending on their location.

Much the same argument would apply to language, culture, traditions, habitats and more. In geopolitics, these borders often shift, inflicting misery on innocent people. The book looks skywards to a borderless horizon, open to the denizens that can fly – Ashok Suri's 'The Sparrow', Ron Pickett's 'Three Doves on the Rooftop', and Ryan Quinn Flanagan's 'House of

Birds', for example.

The implied question in *Wild Winds* is about the dilemma of human existence, where 'home' is situated within a defined country and coded by restrictions. How can one build hope and resilience? Can literature dissolve the differences, melt the fences? Kiriti Sengupta's ironic twist in the poem 'In a Fool's Paradise' exposes the hypocrisies of ritual diplomacy:

When legends depart, admirers claim,/ 'They will come together in heaven,/ share everlasting bliss./ Is there life after death?/ Did these idols commend one another/ when they were alive?

In her Preface, Chakravarty writes: "*Borderless Journal* started with the idea of being a meeting ground for ideas where words transcend to create a proposed utopia, while acknowledging the present realities." For those of us who still believe in principles of care and compassion, humanism and amity, *Wild Winds* is a lifeline to keep afloat in a contaminated sea. It is especially commendable for wrapping global concerns in the fine tissue of hope.

The reviewer, with 24 books, retired as Professor of English, University of Delhi.

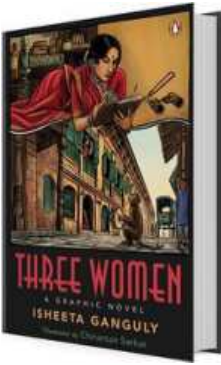


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BROWSER

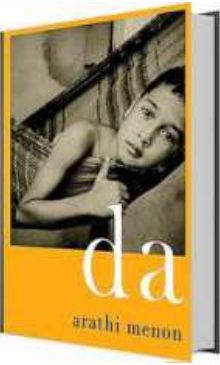
Three Women
Isheeta Ganguly, illus.
Chirantan Sarkar
Penguin
₹299

Three Tagore women – two of them fictional – come together in this graphic novel adaptation of Ganguly's musical drama. The world may have moved from the 19th century to the 21st, but the inner battles of women remain much the same.



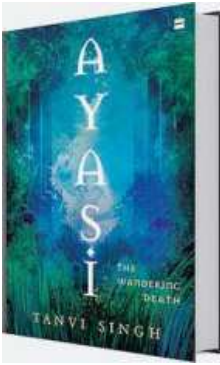
Da
Arathi Menon
Picador
₹399

Why do I have to carry secrets the size of continents, asks witty and inquisitive 13-year-old Ved in this coming-of-age story about growing up with his gay adoptive father. Set against the backdrop of the colonial-era Section 377, this novel explores what it means to love – and be loved.



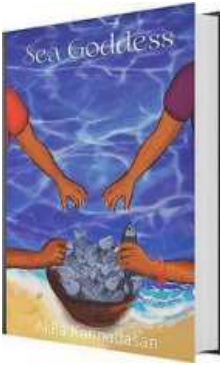
Ayasi
Tanvi Singh
HarperCollins
₹399

The author says she got the idea for the demonic protagonist of her folk horror fantasy tale from a Spanish painting, *Visions Fantasma* by Francisco Goya, that was lost for nearly a century. Women wronged and victimised are the focus of Singh's works.



Sea Goddess
Akila Kannadasan
Vishwakarma Publications
₹299

Drawing on more than a decade of reporting on Tamil Nadu's coastal communities, the author crafts a powerful novel about the sisterhood of fisherwomen. Confronting daily hardship, violence and prejudice, these women invoke the might of the sea to survive and resist.



From prison memoirs and journalistic accounts to novels, the activist shares 10 books that sustained him through six years of incarceration

UMAR KHALID'S PRISON READING LIST

1. *Desperately Seeking Paradise: Journeys of a Sceptical Muslim* by Ziauddin Sardar

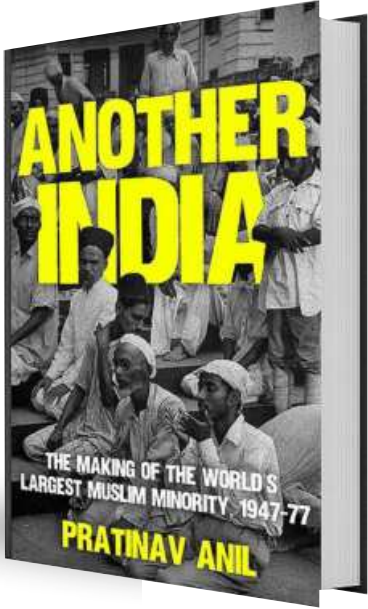
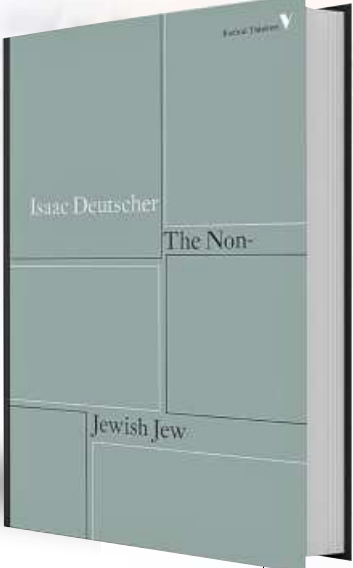
Written sometime in the 1990s, Sardar takes us into the various worlds of contemporary Islam – from the mysticism of the Sufis to the devotion of those associated with the Tablighi Jamaat, from those obsessed with imposing the Shariah in General Zia-ul-Haq's Pakistan to the politics behind the infamous *fatwa* against Salman Rushdie. He also historicises these various contemporary manifestations of what can broadly be called Islamic thought, and foregrounds the rich rationalist and argumentative tradition within the faith.

The book can be read as the author's deeply personal journey of grappling with existential questions of faith and reason, but it is also a rich intellectual history of Islam. Profound in its substance but written in an irreverent, almost conversational style, Sardar leaves us with a historically informed understanding of Islam, which continues to be in short supply.

2. *The Non-Jewish Jew and Other Essays* by Isaac Deutscher

Deutscher, a Polish communist of Jewish origins, reflects in this slim collection of essays on his Jewish identity and heritage. The editors of the compilation emphasise his consistency throughout a tumultuous phase of 20th-century history, ranging from the Russian Revolution to the Holocaust, and later to the creation of Israel and its subsequent wars against Palestinians. At the same time, one can discern subtle shifts within him, as different events pulled him in different directions.

Deutscher shared an ideological affinity with those who saw the Jewish question as inseparable from the class struggle against capitalism. He later came to view the creation of Israel as a historic necessity. Yet he could never reconcile himself to Zionism, and could see the mockery that the state of Israel was making of the Jewish tragedy, as it invoked the memories of Nazi gas chambers in the service of its own genocidal wars against Arabs.



3. *Another India: The Making of the World's Largest Muslim Minority, 1947-77* by Pratinav Anil

Since 2014, faced with the Hindutva juggernaut, liberal discourse has often mourned the demise of India's secularism. In this provocative yet persuasively argued work, Anil demonstrates that there was never really a golden age for India's Muslims.

His focus is on the initial decades of the Indian Republic – the heyday of Nehruvian secularism – and he unsettles many commonly held assumptions. The Constituent Assembly debates witnessed a systematic dismantling of any possibility of constitutional safeguards for India's Muslims. And if the lead in this direction was taken by the Congress leadership of the time, they found a complicit ally in the Ashraf elite from within the Muslim community.

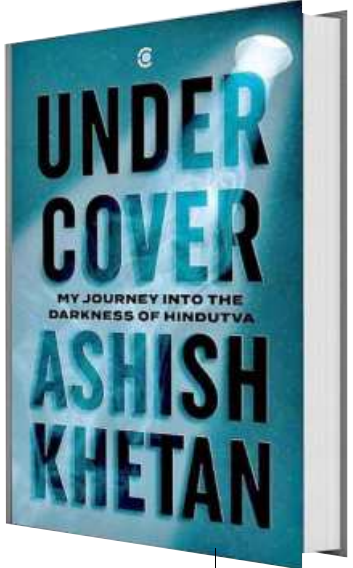
The compromise worked out was this – the Muslims were to give up political questions, and the state in return would not interfere in their personal law. The protection of the Shariat came to substitute for substantive questions of democracy, decentralisation, and representation. The result was that the country's largest minority was disorganised, demobilised, and depoliticised, and left extremely vulnerable.

4. *Undercover: My Journey into the Darkness of Hindutva* by Ashish Khetan

This book brings into focus events that are being actively erased from political discourse, school textbooks, and collective memory.

Khetan, formerly an investigative reporter with *Tehelka*, went undercover with a hidden camera to meet some of the worst perpetrators of the Gujarat riots of 2002. Mistaking him as one of their own, and unaware of the camera recording them, they gleefully narrated in chilling detail the bloody mayhem and mass murders they had unleashed, as well as the official impunity that protected their actions.

Khetan narrates not only the entire process of going undercover but also his later depositions in court that secured the convictions of some of these figures. He also describes how his life never remained the same.

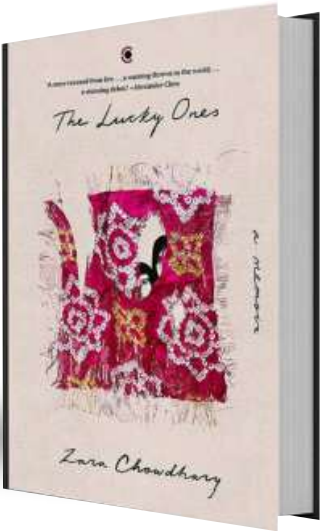


Umar Khalid

Once during his South Africa years, after being sentenced to a few months of imprisonment, M.K. Gandhi remarked that the first thought that crossed his mind after the judge pronounced his sentence was that he was finally going to get the time to read.

In the months preceding my arrest, realising that time was something I was going to have in abundance soon, I had begun curating a reading list. In the last six years, I have voraciously read all that I could lay my hands on and yet I don't think I have ticked even 10% of that original reading list I made in 2020. But at a time when life itself seemed to resemble an Orwellian dystopia, reading has been the only thing that has kept me sane, or so I would like to believe. Here, then, are 10 books I would recommend.

The writer is the author of *Fractured Communities: Adivasi Histories and the Politics of Power*, published by Juggernaut Books.



5. *The Lucky Ones: A Memoir* by Zara Chowdhary

This is about the 2002 Gujarat riots again, but through the eyes of a 16-year-old Muslim girl. As Chowdhary stood on the balcony of her apartment in Ahmedabad in the days after the Godhra incident, she saw smoke rising from different parts of the city. As it inched closer, she wondered whether this fire would engulf them too. They were the lucky ones who survived – or were they?

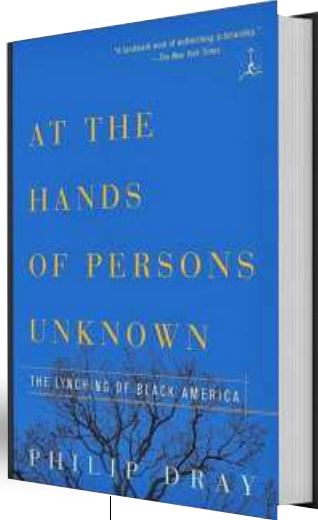
In one particularly evocative part of this memoir, Chowdhary describes her shock at the indifference of her friends when she meets them after a few months, after the violence had led to the closure of schools. For them, those months had been nothing more than an extended vacation. It was as though the smoke, the mobs, the violence simply hadn't existed for them.

It revealed to her something disturbing – the difference in the worlds they inhabit. Her words hauntingly capture what such episodes do to childhoods, and the scars they leave behind.

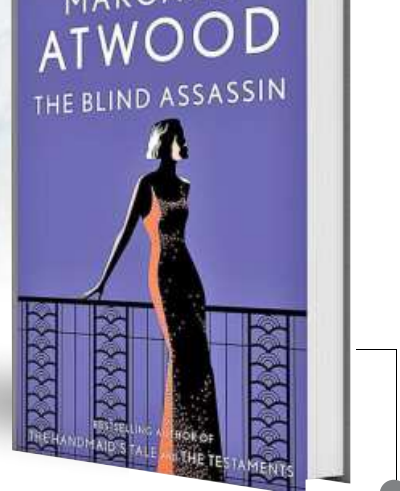
6. *At the Hands of Persons Unknown: The Lynching of Black America* by Philip Dray

Meticulously researched, this work looks at the enactment of violence as a public spectacle against Black people in 19th and 20th century America. From the Jim Crow years, the rise of the Ku Klux Klan, right up to the civil rights movement, Dray reconstructs several instances of lynchings, the mass participation and public sanction they attracted, and the moral codes through which they were justified.

He also introduces us to several remarkable figures from within the Black community who stood up in resistance. His analysis confirms what we too came to realise in our campaign against the lynchings of Muslims and Dalits in India – that this violence is not mindless or spontaneous mob fury, but is connected to the larger project of subordinating a people.



7. *The Blind Assassin* by Margaret Atwood



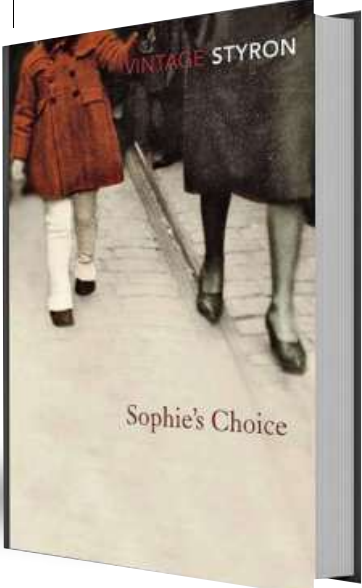
Do we really shape the course of our own lives? Or are our lives shaped by events far beyond our control? This Booker Prize-winning novel explores that question as it follows the lives of two sisters, with the tumultuous events of the first half of the 20th century serving as its backdrop.

One part of the novel traces their lives as they unfold across those decades, while another has one of them looking back nearly 50 years later. The hindsight of the later narrative places the connections between personal lives and larger political events in a perspective that is hard to shake off. This novel remains by far my favourite work of fiction from these years in jail.

8. *Sophie's Choice* by William Styron

In post-war America, Stingo, a young aspiring writer, meets Sophie, a Polish survivor of Auschwitz, who is trapped in an abusive relationship. As the dynamics between the three central characters unfold, Sophie lets Stingo into her past and the terrible choices she was forced to make.

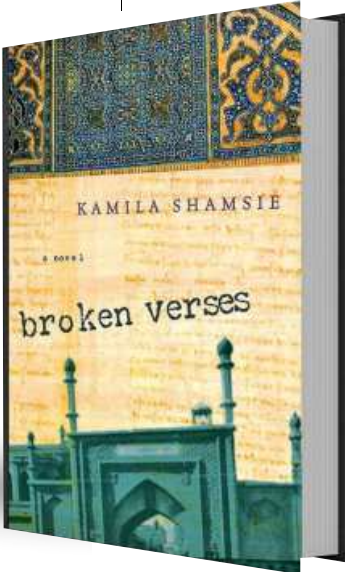
Styron takes us in and out of Nazi concentration camps, laying bare the mechanics of the machinery of mass murder. His writing makes you almost feel the smoke from the gas chambers and smell burnt human flesh, all the while telling a deeply personal story of pain and survival.



9. *Broken Verses* by Kamila Shamsie

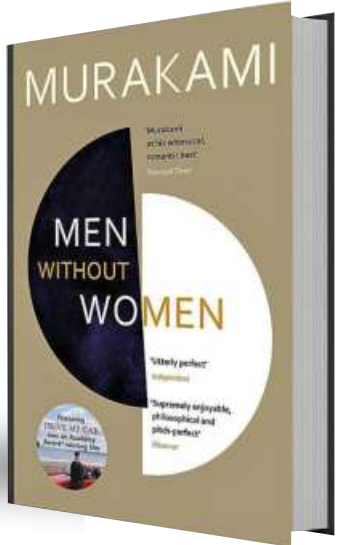
This is the story of a feminist activist in Zia-ul-Haq's Pakistan who, after a lifetime of fighting against oppression, simply vanishes one day. Is she dead or alive? Did she take her own life? Has she gone elsewhere? The novel explores these questions through her daughter's gradual uncovering of her mother's difficult and extraordinary life, and asks the larger question of whether activists too can give up – and it does so with empathy and without judgment.

Read this also for the way the protagonist challenges the regressive and misogynistic moves of the Zia regime, made in the name of Islamisation, by drawing upon traditions and interpretations from within Islamic thought – a territory she refuses to hand over entirely to the state-backed maulvis of the time. I discovered this in the jail library.



10. *Men Without Women* by Haruki Murakami

Murakami is one of the most compelling writers working today. In this collection of short stories, he explores loneliness, love, longing, and desire – not tidily, not with resolution, but with all the messiness and complexity they actually carry. The stories stay with you long after you have finished them, which, in a place like this, is no small thing.



AMERICA AT 250 FIREWORKS AND FAULT LINES

Indian immigrants, students and professionals weigh opportunity against uncertainty, asking if the American Dream is still worth chasing

Nitin Chaudhary

Casie, a co-worker, catches hold of me in the hallway. “So, where will you go to see the fireworks?” Fireworks? My mind goes blank for a moment. “Oh, I mean the July 4 fireworks,” she says, reading the unsure look in my eyes. “Have you made any plans yet? This time will be special. It’s the 250th year.” I have been in the U.S. for exactly one year after spending close to two decades in Sweden. I am still discovering American traditions, and in this first year, I have realised that many of us outside America think we know

the country better than we actually do. Its music, movies, technology, universities, wars, presidents and slogans have travelled so widely that America often feels familiar before one has lived in it. Yet, familiarity is not the same as understanding. The Fourth of July was one such ritual for me. I knew it from films: flags, fireworks, barbecues and marching bands. But as America marks 250 years of independence, I want to understand what the day means to those who live here, those who were born into its story, those who arrived later and made it home, and those who live between more than one country. What emerges is that July 4 is not a simple celebration. It has

evolved into something more layered: gratitude mixed with anxiety, belonging mixed with caution, pride mixed with embarrassment, and a dream that is still alive but no longer unquestioned. A changing vocabulary To understand this changing narrative, I first reach out to Shylashree Edalur, a physician who moved from India to the U.S. in her 20s and has lived in Texas for nearly three decades. America is where her life was built from the bottom up. “America has been home for me since the age of 24,” she tells me. “I had my children here. They are American citizens.” Her story carries the older Indian imagination of America:

the country where education, hard work and professional ambition could move a family from one class position to another. “From my middle-class status, where I am the first physician in my family, and my husband is too, in his family, America has really proven to us that by hard work you can make your dreams come true,” she says. “For me, the American dream is a reality.” That statement would have resonated with generations of Indians who looked at America as the world’s greatest

meritocracy: the destination for higher education, the place of innovation, Silicon Valley and Wall Street, where one could arrive with little more than a degree and ambition, and build a life that may not have been possible elsewhere. The numbers show why the belief has endured. According to Pew Research Center, Indian Americans now number about 5.2 million in the U.S. and are the country’s second-largest Asian-origin group. In 2023, households headed by Indian Americans



From my middle-class status, where I am the first physician in my family, and my husband is too, in his family, America has really proven to us that by hard work you can make your dreams come true. For me, the American dream is a reality

SHYLAHSHREE EDALUR
Physician



Indian Americans waiting to greet India's Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the White House in June 2023; and (below) Modi with U.S. President Donald Trump at the G7 summit in France this June. (GETTY IMAGES, APF)



Sometimes, the reality fails to match the rhetoric, but the idea itself of the American dream and a government by and for the people is still fascinating and noble

NISHQ MODY

wanted exposure, not necessarily permanence. Friends, family and his deeper emotional anchors were still in India. What made him stay was the scale and maturity of opportunity. After working for smaller organisations in California, he moved to Seattle and joined Microsoft. “I broke into the big leagues,” he says. “That was a dream come true for me.” For Avinash, America allowed him to move from technology into business and marketing at a level that India did not yet offer in the same way. Over the years, he did

explore returning to India. But when he spoke to companies there, he felt they recognised the logos on his resume more than the complexity of the work behind them. That, for him, was the reason America continued to matter: not only higher salaries, but the chance to work in markets where his skills are understood and valued. But when Avinash thinks about his daughter’s future, his certainty melts. “Will the U.S. continue to be the global leader? That is a big question mark,” he says. He still believes that if one wants exposure to the biggest technology and AI market in the world, “there is no place like the U.S.”. But the old barriers have dropped. “If you want to learn, you can learn from anywhere in the world today,” he says, adding that India is now a fantastic place to learn and grow in emerging technologies. This is the new reality: not a rejection, but a recalibration of America in the minds of Indians.

The way ahead At 250 years, America remains wealthy, innovative and influential. It is still the country of universities, laboratories, start-ups, capital and scale. But it is also more unequal, more polarised, more anxious about immigration and global competition, and more dependent on immigrant talent than it sometimes admits. On July 4, there were celebratory fireworks and families gathered for shared meals. But beneath it all, the question that continues to haunt is: what does America mean now?

A grand experiment Nishq Mody inhabits that in-between space in a distinct way. An American citizen by birth, with an Indian Parsi father and an English-American mother, he spent significant years growing up in India before returning to the U.S. as an adult. “In America, the Indian aspects of me identify me as the other,” he says. “And when I am in India, people look at me, hear my accent, and recognise me as not Indian.” Mody sees the U.S. as a grand democratic experiment, one that has kept the conversation alive despite setbacks. “Sometimes, the reality fails to match the rhetoric,” he says, “but the idea itself is still fascinating and noble.” For him, the written Constitution, the Bill of Rights, and the idea of a government by and for the people remain significant and an American gift to the world. That may be one way to understand America at 250: not as a finished nation, but as a country still arguing with its founding promise.

I find some hints in these conversations. For Edalur, it is gratitude and caution. For Avinash, it is opportunity shadowed by uncertainty. And for Mody, it is an unfinished democratic experiment. As for me, I went to the town square in Dallas and watched my first July 4 parade. I looked at the flags, the families, the veterans, the immigrants – all gathered at one place in this choreography of belonging. Perhaps this will give me a perspective to wonder how this country will unfold.

The writer is a U.S.-based professional with an interest in travel and culture reporting.



For the first time, Indian Americans have become the target of hatred and resentment. This is coming from both the extreme left and the extreme right, so I would not say the situation is great. Moreover, America is closing its doors to the people who have helped it maintain its global lead. Regardless, the country will reinvent itself as it always does

VIVEK WADHWA
CEO, Vionix Biosciences



As the Supreme Court, the President of the United States, and Republican legislators continue to gut our basic civil and human rights, on this nation's 250th anniversary, I'm thinking about rebirth, renewal and reinvention. I'm envisioning, and working towards, an anti-capitalist, anti-war, anti-genocide, and anti-fascist future. I'm supporting leaders who want universal healthcare, living wages, affordable childcare and housing, as well as funding for community programmes. As a longtime activist, U.S.-born mother of three, this anniversary is a reminder to me that where we are as a country today is not a measure of what we can achieve tomorrow. I'm excited, even hopeful in this moment. More and more Americans have decided that enough is enough, that we need to invest in people instead of PACs/Political Action Committees, corporations, billionaires, propaganda, and a derelict two-party system. Our resistance to the status quo is strong, and it's only getting stronger

ANJALI ENJETI
Author of Ballot

To be Indian American in the U.S. today is to live with a conflicted heart, as these six members of the community explain

CAUGHT BETWEEN HOPE AND DOUBT

Pooja Garg

Across business, medicine, academia, technology, and public life, Indian Americans are one of America's most visible immigrant success stories. But today, there's unease. Indian festivals have recently been facing hostility. Long green card backlogs, uncertainty over the H-B visa, and a rise in anti-Indian hate have deepened anxieties. The Carnegie Endowment's 2026 survey describes the community as going through a period of “turbulence”, with roughly 40% saying they have considered leaving the United States. As America marks 250 years of independence, anxiety coexists with an enduring faith in American opportunity. Six prominent members of the community weigh in:

The writer is an Atlanta-based journalist and USC Annenberg Fellow for Writing and Community Storytelling.



As someone who works to end gender-based violence in our communities, I know that a sense of belonging isn't just symbolic for survivors of violence. It has real consequences for people's safety. When communities feel unwelcome or afraid, survivors are often less likely to seek help, trust institutions, or access the support they need. There is a paradox in loving a country while knowing it has not fully embraced you. We love this country not because it has always lived up to its ideals, but because we believe it can. And because we know her complexity. There are immigrant enclaves where community leaders are cultivating joy, creativity, and safety in resistance to our current climate. And that's the America we love – one where every community can live with dignity, safety, and the opportunity to thrive

SUNDAL ALI

Executive Director, SOAR (Survivors, Organizations, and Allies - Rising)



America has huge potential, and it is a very merit-based economy that gives opportunities to everybody. I think the best part of America is its ability to attract and retain top scientists, educators and management leaders. Despite the negative news you may hear, people experience a great deal of personal freedom here. They feel empowered to pursue their goals and celebrate their cultural traditions while still being a part of American society. America is a land of immigrants, and that is what fuels new ideas, new technologies, and continued innovation. The one expectation is that you work hard. Across professions – whether you are an educator, scientist, medical doctor, lawyer, or in any other occupation – hard work and education are highly valued. The community is well integrated rather than isolated

JAGDISH N. SHETH
Padma Bhushan Awardee and Charles H. Kellstadt Professor of Business, Goizueta Business School, Emory University



I'm certain my parents imagined a different America. My father, a renowned statistician, accepted a job at Florida State University in the 1970s. Like many Indian immigrants of his generation, he saw America as a place where hard work and merit would matter. In many ways, that promise was fulfilled. But America has always been more complicated than the ideal they embraced. I don't think my parents ever imagined an

America that did not welcome immigrants. Or an America that did not embrace multiculturalism and diversity. Politics [today] has most definitely changed everyday life, though perhaps less in dramatic ways than in subtle ones. As a journalist and educator, I've watched trust erode, conversations become more polarised, and facts become contested. As America turns 250, the question that looms for me is: can a nation truly celebrate its history if it isn't willing to confront all of it? Because it seems that the current administration is not willing to embrace the stories of people who have been marginalised or forgotten or erased. Or the stories of immigrants like me. But I believe the pendulum will swing the other way again one day. I have to remain optimistic. Otherwise, the dreams that my family carried with them to America don't have a chance of surviving

MONI BASU

Director of Narrative Nonfiction, University of Georgia, and ex-CNN

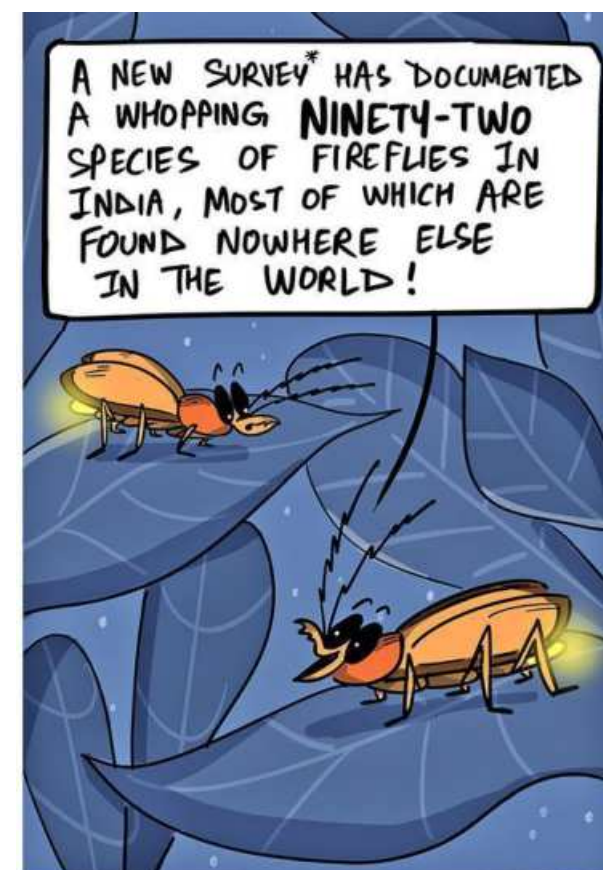


I came to America five decades ago with a suitcase and a student visa. Only in this country could a foreign student return as the commencement speaker at his alma mater. Only in America could an immigrant become a citizen and later have the privilege of welcoming other new citizens at a presidential library. America gave me opportunity, purpose, family, and the chance not only to live the American dream, but to contribute to it in return

M.R. RANGASWAMI
Founder, Indiaspora

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



A birth certificate is not “proof” of birth,” a senior official from the Union Ministry of Birth, Death and Rebirth told me last week. He added, “There's a common misconception that a birth certificate, which contains your date and place of your birth and the names of your Papa and Mamma, constitutes conclusive proof that you have been born. But that is not necessarily true.”

Coming on the heels of the news that possessing an Indian passport is not proof of Indian citizenship (or the citizenship of any other country), this has left 1.48 billion Indians stunned, many of whom believe that their existence was preceded by their birth. Also, for many Indians, proof of birth is a crucial piece of evidence that helps build a case for Indian citizenship. Given the grave implications for every Indian, I convinced the official to clear the air in an exclusive interview.

Question: Sir, before we begin, can I see some proof that you are an Indian citizen? Answer: No, you may not. Citizenship proof is a requirement only for the citizens of India, not for the rulers of India.

Q: If the birth certificate is not proof of birth, what use is it? A: Just as your passport is a

ALLEGEDLY Proof of birth pending

An official clears up a few misconceptions

travel document and not a proof of your citizenship, your birth certificate is also a travel document and not a proof of your birth.

Q: How is a birth certificate a travel document? I cannot use it to travel anywhere. A: On the contrary, you have already used it – to travel from the afterlife to your current birth. It is also a travel document in a symbolic sense: it accompanies you in the journey of your life, from birth to death.

Q: The birth certificate is a key document for claiming Indian citizenship. But for the longest time, India did not have a system of issuing mandatory birth certificates. How can someone who doesn't have a birth certificate get one? A: Excellent question, Mr. Sampath. I'm so glad you asked me this. The government has a clearly defined process for anyone who doesn't already possess a

birth certificate. In fact, when the current regime came to power for the first time, it took a conscious decision to get rid of outdated Western colonial practices. We now follow a uniquely Indic process that stays true to our ancient traditions dating back millennia, to the era of Aryabhata, Chanakya, zero, and Mussolini. In fact, when Brahmagupta, the grand-uncle of Samudragupta...

Q: We don't have much time, sir. Please answer my question. A: I was, and I am, answering your question. You are beginning to sound like an annoying, immature Norwegian journalist. Are you really a citizen of India? Anyway, coming to your stupid question, there is indeed a way for an Indian without a birth certificate to procure a fresh birth certificate, and that is by getting born again.

Q: How can a person

who is already born get born again? A: If you were a bona fide Indian citizen, you wouldn't be asking this question. You would be cognisant of the karmic cycle of births, deaths and rebirths, and would know that even if you are born without a birth certificate in one birth, it's not a big deal – you can get it in your next birth.

Q: What if, in my next birth, I am born in some other country? A: Which country?

Q: The U.S., for instance. A: Then you have nothing to worry. If you are a true Indian, you will dedicate yourself to helping other Indians get American citizenship.

Q: What if I am reborn in India only, but as a cockroach? A: In that case, you can always join the Cockroach Janata Party.

Q: Suppose I don't have a birth certificate, don't believe in rebirth, and don't have a passport, but I was born to Indian parents, brought up in India, and have 30 years of income tax returns as evidence that my hard-earned money has gone into your salary and funded all 77 of your foreign trips. Surely, I'm entitled to some official acknowledgement of my Indian citizenship, don't you think? A: What do you mean you have a right? Citizenship of India is a privilege, not a right, and you have to earn it – by proving that you deserve it.

Q: How do I do that? A: By not asking questions, for starters. Secondly, you should be a born-again Indian.

Q: How do I prove myself a born-again Indian? A: You can't. We will decide that for you, when we receive your application.

G. Sampath, the author of this satire, is Social Affairs Editor, The Hindu.



As Messi, Ronaldo, Djokovic and Kohli enter their last chapters, the games they defined are about to change

Sport after the GOATs

Suresh Menon

Four great contemporary champions are in action simultaneously. The oldest, Cristiano Ronaldo, is 41, and playing his final World Cup, as is Lionel Messi, 39. In England, Novak Djokovic, 39, is attempting a record 25th Grand Slam title. Playing nearby will be Virat Kohli, 38, cricket's version of the others.

For nearly two decades, these men owned sporting time. But all sport conspires against longevity. Before Messi won a World Cup four years ago, many had already written his epilogue; but he is showing his hunger again. Ronaldo continues scoring with the determination of a man negotiating with biology. Djokovic keeps returning from injuries and controversies. Kohli remains Kohli, only more so. All very

inspiring, possibly absurd too. Great athletes normalise absurdity, delaying our tryst with middle age.

Djokovic began as the inconvenient third man in a love story featuring Roger Federer and Rafael Nadal. By the time history paused to count, he had accumulated numbers that demanded conversations about the greatest of all time, the fan's favourite acronym, GOAT. He became statistically the greatest while never quite becoming the sport's most universally beloved. Sport, like literature, prefers flawed heroes to perfect accountants.

In search of a unique hero Significantly, as these athletes prepare to leave, their sports are in transition. Football belongs increasingly to systems, data models



and pressing structures. The geometry of straight lines is taking over from the poetry of curves. The artist still exists, but is measured by sprint distances and defensive recoveries. Tennis has become a contest of physical power played at high speed by competitors who have inherited the standards Djokovic himself set. Ironically, the champions shaped the landscape that will eventually exclude them.

This was not always so. Roger Federer was fit, but not ridiculously so. Diego Maradona, whose feet painted some of the most colourful canvases in the game, was a less self-destructive Messi. The present could be explained in terms of the past.

Now, sport seems destined to go through a phase dictated by Artificial Intelligence before the unique hero emerges, unexplainable in terms of either AI or past champions. Carlos Alcaraz and Jannik Sinner and Vaibhav Suryavanshi and Ousmane Dembélé seem to be preparation for this. They are not the past. It is easy to see them as visitors from the future, but that is fraught too. Individual brilliance will emerge not as part of a continuum, but in opposition to it.

Sport is changing not just technically and in the manner fans ('customers') consume it, but in a more fundamental way.

Reducing toxic nationalism I belong to the generation which believed that there is no greater glory for an athlete than representing their country at the highest level. It was an article of faith. But the sands have shifted beneath my feet. I am no longer so sure.

It might have something to do with the 48 teams in the World Cup, many of whom would struggle against a European club side. Or India losing a T20 series in Ireland, a country low down the pecking order. The idea of the 'highest level' is changing. It is not always the national side.

This might not be such a bad thing. It will reduce the toxic nationalism of the World Cups and the Olympics. It is interesting to watch Messi play for Argentina, but watching Messi, Brazilian Neymar Júnior and Frenchman Kylian Mbappé play together for Paris Saint-Germain can be more thrilling. There is an element of purity here: sport as it ought to be played, with the best in action regardless of country affiliations.

Club vs. country is an old argument, as is the gradual evolution from one to the other. There is a strong case for the World Cup when you realise that about 70% of the players might not get worldwide attention otherwise. The impact of such exposure is huge for the sport in their countries. Clubs controlling a sport will lead to monopolies, and take it beyond the average fan. It is a good moral argument. Sport, however, does not evolve morally. Money, convenience, politics, media influence its direction.

Goodbyes in sport are reminders of our own mortality. What unites Messi, Djokovic, Kohli and Ronaldo is both prolonged excellence and durability, a rare combination. In their final days at the top, we realise what impossible standards they set, standards we have taken for granted.

The writer's latest book is Why Don't You Write Something I Might Read?.

Bob Jones

North stretched a little when he supported hearts at the three level, but that is normal under the pressure of competition. South had plenty to carry on to game, but the game was not cold. Assuming the hearts split no worse than 3-1, South had one spade, six hearts, one club, and he could force a diamond trick. That

was nine tricks and the only realistic chance for a tenth was a ruff in dummy. The problem was that East probably had only two spades, so a spade ruff in dummy would have to be with the ace. That would leave South needing an unlikely 2-2 trump split. South thought of a better plan.

South won the opening spade lead with his ace and led another spade as East high-logged in the suit.

GOREN BRIDGE

Thoughtful play

Neither vulnerable, South deals

West won the second spade with the jack and led the queen of spades. Instead of ruffing in dummy, South shed a low diamond. West shifted to a club to South's ace.

South led a diamond to dummy's king and East's ace. East led the 10 of diamonds to South's queen as West played the jack. That worried declarer. West might have

NORTH		WEST		SOUTH	
♥ 10 5	♠ K Q J 7 3 2	♥ A 8 4	♠ K Q 7 6 3 2	♥ A 8 4	♠ K Q 7 6 3 2
♦ A 5 4	♥ 9	♦ A 10 9 6 4	♥ K Q J 7	♦ K 8 3	♥ A
♣ K 7 2	♣ 10 9 8 4	♣ K J 7			
♣ Q 6 5 3 2					

The bidding:			
SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
1♥	2♠	3♥	Pass
4♥	All pass		

Opening lead: King of ♠

one heart and only two diamonds, so South took the precaution of cashing the king of hearts before leading his last diamond. If West could ruff, the contract would be secure after dummy over-ruffed.

When West discarded a spade, South ruffed with dummy's five of hearts. The ace of hearts and a club ruff saw South back in his hand to draw the last trump and claim. Nicely done!

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

What has July 5 ever given us!



On July 5, 2016, NASA's Juno spacecraft entered orbit around this planet to carry out studies. (GETTY IMAGES)

Berty Ashley

On July 5, 1643, Massachusetts Governor John Winthrop recorded the first known account of a weather phenomenon in American history. The violent "sudden gust" struck Essex County, destroying a meeting house in Newbury, tearing through Lynn, and killing a Native American who was struck by a falling tree. What was this phenomenon?

On July 5, 1687, the Latin book *Philosophiæ Naturalis Principia Mathematica* was published. Across its roughly 500 pages, it laid the mathematical foundations of classical mechanics. Who was its author,

after whom the laws of motion were then named?

Born on July 5, 1879, Wanda Landowska was a musician who made the first recording of Bach's 'Goldberg Variations' on an instrument that became closely associated with Baroque music. Though it resembles a piano, its strings are plucked rather than struck. What instrument is this which is basically a harp on the side?

On July 5, 1937, Hormel Foods introduced this brand of processed meat. It later entered popular culture through a Monty Python sketch in which diners are relentlessly encouraged to order it. The sketch gave rise to what

now-dreaded term in computing?

On July 5, 1946, French model Micheline Bernardini stepped out of a swimming pool in Paris, debuting a brand new item of clothing. Named in reference to a nuclear test done four days prior by the U.S., it did have an explosive response. What now common beachwear was this?

Born July 5, 1958, Bill Watterson is a beloved American illustrator best known for a comic strip about a six-year-old boy and his stuffed tiger. Which series did he create that has made newspaper readers laugh all around the world?

Born July 5, 1985, Megan Rapinoe is the only footballer, male or female, to have scored an

'Olympic goal' at two Olympic Games. She scored directly from an angle in line with the goal. When it doesn't result in a goal, what is this set piece called?

On July 5, 1996, the Roslin Institute in Scotland announced the birth of a sheep. This sheep's birth and its six-year lifespan directly contributed to major advances in cloning and stem cell research. What was the name of the sheep?

On July 5, 2012, the London Bridge Tower was inaugurated as the tallest building in Europe. The glass-clad pyramidal tower was criticised for resembling a giant jagged piece of glass, giving rise to the name by which it is now universally known. What's it called?

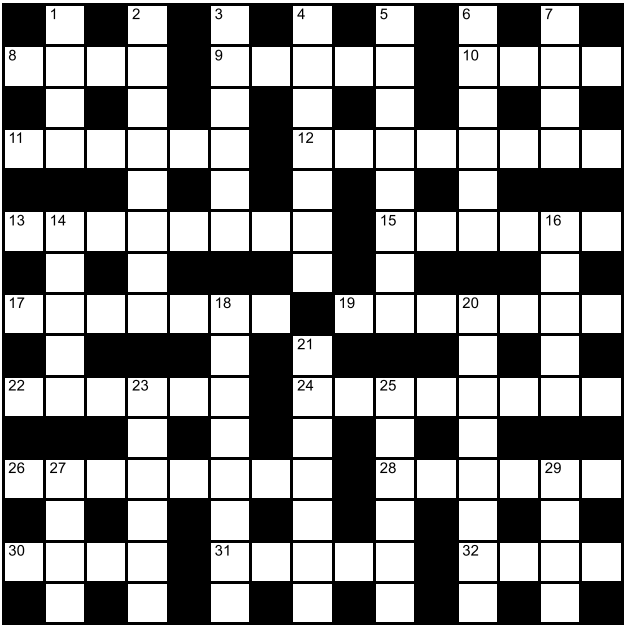
On July 5, 2016, NASA's Juno spacecraft entered orbit around a planet to carry out studies. Named after the Roman goddess Juno, who was said to keep watch over her husband, what was his name?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

- 1. Tom Hanks
- 2. Isaac Newton
- 3. Harpsichord
- 4. Spm
- 5. Bklnh
- 6. Calvin & Hobbes
- 7. Corner kick
- 8. Dolly
- 9. The Shard
- 10. Jupiter

Answers

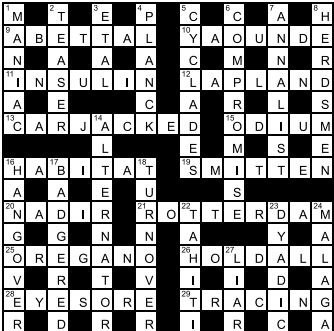
THE SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 63 Set by Incognito



- Across**
- 8 Perhaps, Christian boy with a drink? (4)
 - 9 A tub that is damaged and having a hole in it? This vessel may be underwater... (1-4)
 - 10 Times editor, at first, is surrounded by swirling gas (4)
 - 11 Fox appearing in The Day of the Jackal (6)
 - 12 Communist, having kidnapped a pretty girl, mutinied (8)
 - 13 Decrease from the moons orbiting (8)
 - 15 Nero dances in front of engineer getting dress (6)
 - 17 Type of gland, perhaps, having real DNA mutation (7)
 - 19 Tan sari manufactured for empress (7)
 - 22 Entertains American with U.S. bridge players (6)
 - 24 Put off excited toffs carrying Greek letter and going around university (5,3)
 - 26 Nothing left, okay? (3,5)
 - 28/32 Noise by Indiana man to be married in part of house (6,4)
 - 30 Joint from shank needed (4)
 - 31 Silly in an exhibition at first (5)
 - 32 See 28
- Down**
- 1 Musical group from Porbandar (4)
 - 2 Insane demon ate worm (8)
 - 3 Turning up at end of hour, had returned veil (6)
 - 4 Badly ignore German air chief during WW2 (7)
 - 5 Best bars moulded for assailants using sharp instruments (8)
 - 6 Mariner from small oil tanker leaving Kent

- and sailing (6)
- 7 Manufactured cashmere without scam at this place (4)
- 14 Lady remains unchanged on retirement (5)
- 16 Wrap turban in absence of right African people (5)
- 18 Spears animal in front of drunken sage around one (8)
- 20 About financial penalty on railway for oil processing unit (8)
- 21 Smoker's accessory from trash thrown by a Yankee (7)
- 23 Della in Mason books and Baker in Holmes stories (6)
- 25 Perhaps, what Dracula does... briefs, for example... (6)
- 27 What uncle did with money in period before Easter? (4)
- 29 Either way, it's middle of the day (4)

SOLUTION NO. 62



Investing time and attention in OTT series

Akash S.
akashs326@gmail.com

There is a strange kind of silence that comes after finishing an exciting OTT series. You complete the last episode, stare at the screen for a few extra seconds, and suddenly feel like something is missing. The next day feels slightly dull. You open the streaming app again without thinking, hoping there is one more episode left. Even when you know the season is over, your mind is still somewhere inside that story.

It is surprising how emotionally attached people have become to OTT shows. People spend entire nights watching the same characters laugh, suffer, fall in love, and break up. After 10 to 15 hours with the same fictional world, attachment becomes unavoidable.

What makes these series feel personal is not only the story itself, but the time spent with it. Viewers begin recognising small details about characters the way they would with real people. Their habits become familiar. Their dialogues stay in memory. Sometimes people even start looking forward to returning to those fictional worlds after stressful days, almost like visiting familiar friends.

Binge watching makes the emotional connection even stronger. Earlier, television forced people to pause and wait. OTT platforms removed that gap completely.

This is why season endings affect people more than they expect. The sadness is not really about a show ending. It is about suddenly losing a space that had quietly become part of daily life. A routine disappears with it. The excitement of continuing the story disappears too. Even small things feel strange afterward, like opening dinner without an episode playing in the background.

Many people try extending the experience instead of letting it end. They watch interviews, scroll through fan pages, read online discussions, and send reels related to the show to friends. Some immediately restart older episodes because they are not emotionally ready to leave that world behind yet.

Social media has made this attachment even more intense. Earlier, people watched shows and moved on privately. Today, every popular OTT series becomes part of online conversation. Fans argue about endings, create memes, analyse scenes and emotionally react together in real time. Watching no longer feels like an individual experience. It feels collective.

Some people may call this unhealthy attachment, but stories have always affected human beings deeply. They waited eagerly for newspaper serials and radio dramas too. The only difference today is that OTT platforms make stories accessible and immersive.

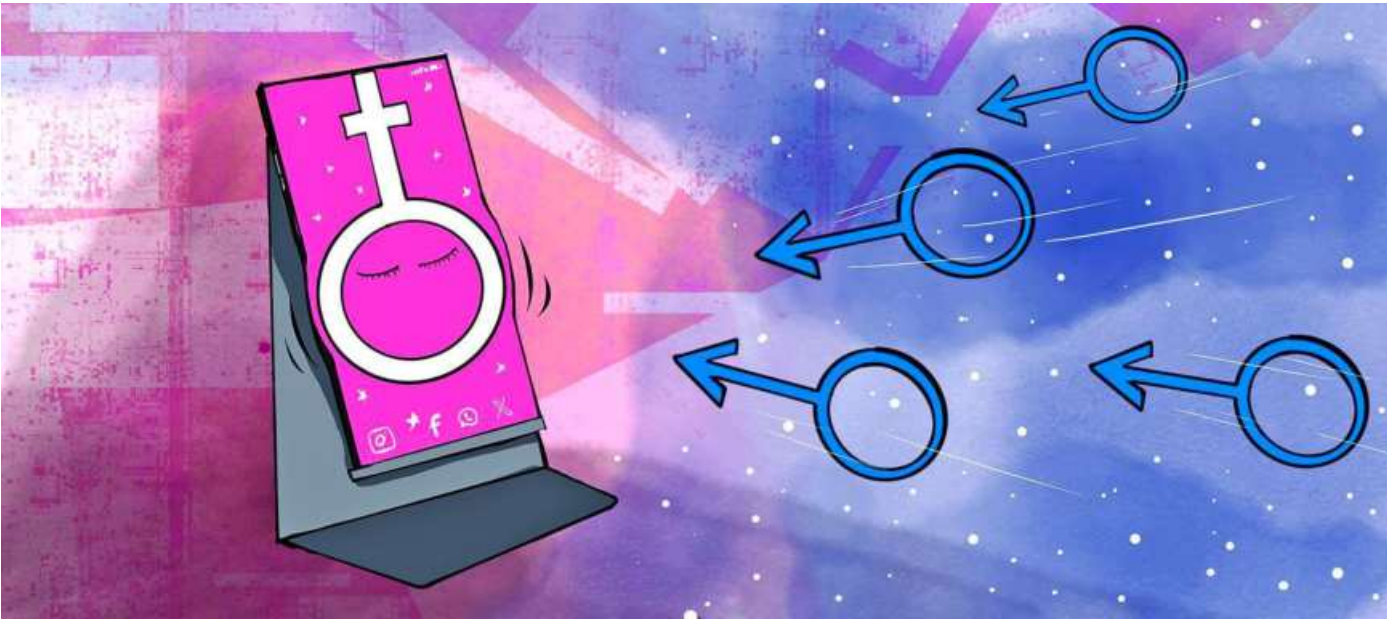


ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

Ambica Naithani
ambicanaithani.work@gmail.com

Across 13 countries and 104 women in an age group spanning five decades, all connected by one experience, shows a survey conducted by me through Google Forms and publicised on social media platforms. The common experience is a feeling of being observed and measured.

Popular culture has set beauty standards so bizarre that women often feel trapped in an impossible cycle of scrutiny. It may not be explicit yet it's constant: a relative's comment, a reaction reel on Instagram, or a fashion trend that quietly reclassifies an entire body type as undesirable. Women's bodies remain a subject of public debate in a way that men's do not. The findings illuminate insights on the complicated relationship many women have with their bodies as a consequence of the unrealistic beauty standards that exist.

Unsolicited remarks
Of the women surveyed, 83% have experienced unsolicited remarks on their bodies by family members. "I was shamed for being fat, called derogatory names in school, and bullied by classmates and family... pushing me towards depression, a borderline eating disorder, even suicidal thoughts," one of them says.

Internet slang such as "almond mom" is testament to the shared experiences of women of all sizes facing pressure from loved ones to look a certain way. Another said, "Only fair-skinned girls are given opportunities in school functions to be at the front stage."

Women face unwarranted comments outside the family too: "I work out but people comment on my weight and eating proportions saying I'm too skinny."

With the advent of the Internet, body shaming is propagated, subliminally if not overtly, through media. Media representations have a demonstrable tendency to influence conversation, fashion, belief, culture, and behaviour.

Asked if they felt represented in the media, a participant said: "It is an 'othered' representation of body type; as less desirable.... It is shown as

The tyranny of beauty standards: one story fits all

Addressing this will require accountability from platforms, publications, and institutions that continue to act as the authority on how women's bodies are perceived and judged

a valiant fight to be comfortable in your own body."

"There are more plus-sized actors but they usually fall under the 'desirable' body types... representation feels very 'sanitised' for popular gaze," a respondent said. Another noted how representation shifts with trends: "A few years ago, curvier women became represented but with Y2K fashion trends, smaller body types have become more 'fashionable' again."

Trimming the plate
Consider the films *Gone With The Wind* (1939) and *Luckiest Girl Alive* (2022). Though released 91 years apart, both show women curbing their appetite in front of men. Of the respondents, 52% said they felt hesitant to eat as much as they wanted while dining publicly.

When women build community in virtual spaces to seek comfort in shared experiences, they still risk abuse online. On social media, 98% of participants said they had witnessed mid- to plus-size women being harassed online, while 92% said they had seen women bullied for being petite or "too skinny". Certain corners of the Internet have long harboured communities that glorify disordered eating, actively encouraging young girls towards anorexia and bulimia.

The romanticisation of specific bone structures such as thigh gaps and collarbones, framed as aspirational, has had documented consequences on the mental health of adolescent girls.

Of the participants, 88% said they felt overwhelmed by beauty standards online: "How is one to do skincare, gym, cook, eat healthy food, get good sleep, with a 9-5, doing chores?" The question points to something larger: how many of these insecurities are manufactured by an economy that profits from women's self-doubt.

As much as 86% said they found information on weight-management confusing and contradictory, a problem compounded by the fact that fitness research had historically centred male subjects, leaving little accessible science on how the menstrual cycle affected strength and endurance. Many influencers focus solely on aesthetic goals while claiming to champion "health".

As one participant put it: "The Internet makes you feel all your health ailments are because you are fat."

Structural failure
This survey brings forth not just a catalogue of grievances but a portrait of structural failure, in media, medicine and design of online spaces. The women surveyed are not outliers, they represent a majority navigating beauty standards dependent on trend cycles and algorithms which sustain industries that profit from dissatisfaction. Individual resilience in a space such as this may fall short. Addressing this would require accountability from platforms, publications and institutions which continue to act as the authority on how women's bodies are perceived and judged.



FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

The cover story captures a quiet revolution unfolding in Indian kitchens. ('Domestic cooks of the digital age'; June 28) Domestic cooks learning global recipes through YouTube and Reels is not merely a culinary shift — it reflects their determination to upskill despite structural disadvantages. Employers must recognise this effort through better wages. Platforms offering recipe content in regional languages would make this digital kitchen more inclusive and equitable.
K. Sakunthala

Just yesterday, my wife prepared *bisi bele bath* by following a YouTube recipe. A few days earlier, my daughter-in-law cooked a delicious Kashmiri chicken dish the same way. Similar experiences are becoming common in households around the world. Through YouTube and social media, recipes and culinary traditions now travel effortlessly across countries, bringing diverse flavors into our homes.
P.K. Ashok

Tropes and traps

The review of *Yesteryear* rightly notes that the novel sacrifices thematic depth for narrative pace. ('Unpacking the tradwife fantasy'; June 28) Readers hoping for sharp feminist critique may find the book entertaining yet somewhat hollow in its social commentary.
Abbharna Barathi

Dino power

Steve Brusatte's observation that India is simply gripped by fear after Phuphee's warning. Fear can sometimes achieve what sermons cannot do.
Harsh Pawaria



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"I have a room all to myself; it is nature," wrote the American poet and philosopher Henry David Thoreau in his journal. I did not understand that line when I first read it. A room full of nature sounded poetic, but I suspected it might also be a polite way of saying, "I am alone, and I must make peace with it."

My earliest experience of being alone had nothing graceful about it. One summer, I stayed back at home while the rest of the family travelled for a wedding. The house, usually loud with conversations and the clatter of vessels, suddenly behaved like a library that had lost its readers. I switched on television, then the radio, then even kept the lights on during the day, as if brightness could chase away the strange emptiness that followed me from room to room.

I had space, silence, and freedom. Yet, something was missing. Meals tasted mechanical, sleep felt restless, and even my favourite book refused to hold my attention. It was not the absence of

When alone feels so perfect

Loneliness whispers something is missing; solitude, however, gently replies that nothing is lacking

GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

people alone. It was the feeling that something essential had stepped out and forgotten to return. That was loneliness quietly settling in.

Stumbling into solitude
Years later, life offered me a contrasting scene. I was waiting alone at a railway station, delayed by an unkind timetable. The platform was less crowded. A tea vendor poured steaming cups with

the precision of a practised artist. A stray dog slept with enviable peace. I sat on a wooden bench, watching people come and go, each carrying their own small universe.

This time, I did not resist the silence. I allowed it to stay. The sounds around me felt clearer. I noticed the rhythm of footsteps, the whistle of a distant train, the brief exchanges between strangers.

My thoughts appeared and settled without insistence. There was no urge to escape the moment. I was alone, certainly not lonely. Something within felt settled rather than lacking.

That quiet shift marked the difference. Loneliness had earlier made its presence felt by what it took away. That afternoon, without any grand announcement, I had stumbled into solitude.

The distinction is subtle but unmistakable. Loneliness keeps pointing to an empty chair at the table. Solitude invites you to sit comfortably, even as that chair remains unoccupied. One creates a restless search, the other a quiet acceptance.

I began to test this understanding in small, everyday ways. I started taking morning walks without my phone, letting thoughts rise and settle like birds on a wire. I sat occasionally with a cup of coffee without the urgency to check messages. I even tried dining alone in a restaurant once, expecting discomfort. Instead, there was an unexpected ease. Conversations around me flowed, waiters moved efficiently, and I remained a silent observer, quite at peace.

Of course, there are moments when the old feeling returns. A festival evening, a piece of good news, a sudden memory... The human desire to connect does not fade, nor should it. Even Rainer Maria Rilke, who wrote so beautifully about solitude, admitted that relationships remain central to our lives. I do not deny that. There is a difference between seeking connection out of joy and seeking it to fill a void. I only understand it better now.

Loneliness whispers, "Something is missing." Solitude gently replies, "Nothing is lacking."

Silence carries comfort
Today, I no longer treat my own company as a waiting room for others to arrive. It has become a space where thoughts find clarity and silence carries comfort. It is a place where I can sit, think, wander, and sometimes simply be. And in that quiet acceptance, I have discovered a small, steady truth.

When I begin to enjoy my own company, I no longer fear being alone. Perhaps that is what Thoreau meant after all. Not the absence of people, but the presence of ease within oneself.



Meenakshi N. Ahamed

I wrote a book called *Indian Genius: The Meteoric Rise of Indians in America* (2024). The subtitle captures the essence of the book. When I embarked on the project in 2021, it was virtually impossible to turn on CNN, read the *Wall Street Journal*, go to a hospital, attend a university, or browse a bookstore in America without encountering a sea of Indian names and faces.

During his tenure, President Barack Obama had appointed Dr. Vivek Murthy, an Indian American, as the surgeon general, and in 2021, President Joe Biden reappointed him. Two of the largest Fortune 500 companies – Microsoft and Google – were headed by CEOs born, raised, and educated through their undergraduate years in India. Headlines like ‘Indian Immigrants Are Tech’s New Titans’ were splashed across the press.

And, after the Mars rover Perseverance touched down on February 18, 2021, President Biden called Swati Mohan, a lead scientist at NASA, to congratulate her. “It’s amazing,” he said. “Indian-descent Americans are taking over the country – you, my vice-president [Kamala Harris], my speechwriter [Vinay Reddy]. You guys are incredible.” It felt like the apogee of the Indian American story.

As America celebrates 250 years of independence this year, that story reads very differently – and, increasingly, so does the story of the country’s relationship with India itself. Both have deteriorated in tandem, and that is the real story of this anniversary year for the diaspora: not just a community feeling more vulnerable at home, but a homeland relationship souring at the same time, leaving Indian Americans squeezed from both directions.

Attack on diversity and inclusion Emma Lazarus’s poem “The New Colossus”, inscribed on the Statue of Liberty, gave succour to generations of immigrants sailing into New York’s harbour: *Give me your tired, your poor, your huddled masses yearning to breathe free...* Every president, Republican or Democrat, since Franklin D. Roosevelt has reinforced that message in some form. Ronald Reagan, in his 1989 farewell address, described America as a shining city on a hill, teeming with people of all kinds living in harmony and peace.

The Trump administration has jettisoned that inheritance. It has pursued an aggressive anti-immigration agenda and tried to end diversity and inclusion across universities and employment. It has signalled an explicit preference for white immigration, as when it offered visas to white South Africans on the unsubstantiated claim that they face discrimination in their own country. During a 2018 immigration meeting, Trump referred to Haiti, El Salvador and African nations as

AMERICA AT 250

THE DIASPORA AT A CROSSROADS

Rising exclusion and strained U.S.-India ties have left many Indian Americans navigating divided identities



(Clockwise from left) Comedian Zarna Garg; physician Siddhartha Mukherjee; actor Mindy Kaling; author Suketu Mehta; and TV host Padma Lakshmi. (GETTY IMAGES)



Prominent Indian Americans have been debating how to secure the community’s future: should they give more to charity, run for more public office (currently six Indian Americans sit in Congress), or find better ways to convey how many jobs Indian-led companies have created rather than taken? These questions feel more urgent than they did even three years ago

thousand Indians were deported on U.S. charter flights while handcuffed and shackled. It was a political embarrassment for the Modi government. Many Indians had expected a return to the warm Trump-Modi chemistry of his first term; instead, the partnership steadily declined and India found itself shoring up other relationships.

On August 6, 2025, Trump imposed 50% tariffs on India over its trade barriers and continued purchases of Russian oil – among the highest tariffs levied on any U.S. trading partner. He went on to describe the U.S.-India relationship “very one-sided” on social media, while his trade officials accused New Delhi of helping finance Russia’s war effort through its oil purchases. India denounced the measures as “unfair, unjustified and unreasonable,” insisting its energy policy reflected strategic autonomy rather than hostility towards Washington. Unwilling to strain the relationship further, Modi skipped an online BRICS leaders’ summit hosted by Brazil in September 2025 to discuss U.S. trade policies and tariffs, with his foreign minister participating instead.

The damage was not merely rhetorical. Indian markets became the worst-performing among emerging economies in 2025, with foreign investors pulling out at record levels. India responded not by capitulating but by hedging: it signalled intent to diversify its partnerships, engaging more closely with Russia’s Putin and China’s Xi, and in January 2026, it signed a landmark Free Trade Agreement with the European Union.

Recently, there has been some thaw – Trump cut tariffs on Indian exports from 50% to 18% in February 2026 after Indian oil companies agreed to curtail Russian crude purchases. Working-level cooperation on defence has held up better than the political relationship; the two countries renewed their bilateral defence framework for another 10 years in October 2025. But the underlying trust between the two countries, painstakingly built up by former presidents Bill Clinton, George W. Bush, and Obama, has come under severe pressure over the past year.

▲ An Independence Day parade by the Indian American community in Scranton, Pennsylvania. (GETTY IMAGES)

For the diaspora, this dual deterioration – racial and geopolitical – lands differently than either development would on its own. It is one thing to feel that your adopted country has grown less welcoming to people who look like you. It is another to watch your country of origin be publicly demeaned by the same administration, with little pushback from your own government. Indian Americans have found themselves without a fully reliable advocate on either side of the relationship.

The demand-supply equation It is worth remembering how this community got here in the first place, because the current backlash erases that history. Indian migration to the U.S. began in earnest after immigration laws were relaxed in 1965, driven as much by America’s own needs as by Indian ambition. In the early days of the Cold War, the U.S. military feared losing the space race to the Soviet Union after the success of *Sputnik* in 1957. They poured money into research, only to find a shortage of engineers; European migration had slowed just as India’s first IIT graduates were entering the workforce, and the match was a natural one.

In 1965, the Medicare Act made around 20 million Americans newly eligible for healthcare even as the Vietnam War pulled doctors into the field, and returning soldiers swelled hospital caseloads at home. India’s medical schools, with their English-speaking graduates, helped fill the gap; physicians Abraham Verghese and Deepak Chopra were among those who came during this period. Even today, around 40% of physicians in rural America and in hospitals serving low-income families are foreign-trained, many of them Indian.

The results of that 50-year partnership are extraordinary by any measure. In 1970, there were just 51,000 Indians in America; today there are over 5 million. They have the highest median household income of any ethnic group in the country – \$151,200 versus \$92,350 for white households, according to 2021-23 Census data. Around 60% of that population arrived after the 1990s tech boom, making it one of the fastest ascents of any immigrant community in American history.

Between home and homeland At a town hall organised by Indiaspora, a diaspora network, prominent Indian Americans debate how to secure the community’s future: should they give more to charity, run for more public office (currently six Indian Americans sit in Congress), or find better ways to convey how many jobs Indian-led companies have created rather than taken? These questions feel more urgent than they did even three years ago.

Over the past 18 months, speaking to audiences across the country, I find that the doubling of the Indian American population has produced an Indian-majority presence in a handful of suburbs – and with it, new friction. An older white man in Seattle told me after a talk that while he respects the contribution Indians have made, he resents what he sees as a refusal to integrate: Indian families who don’t show up to community events, who have effectively taken over the local schools, who stick to themselves even on the playground. His grievance, he says, is cultural – the sense of being made unwelcome in his own town.

That insularity is not accidental. Many of the roughly 3 million Indian Americans who arrived on H-1B visas after 2000 remain deeply tied to India culturally and through family, and some have not decided whether they are staying for good. Several tell me their reasoning is almost strategic: to be able to re-enter Indian life seamlessly someday, it makes more sense for them to stay within Indian social and cultural circles rather than assimilate fully. They have not yet decided whether July 4 means more to them than August 15.

As both the welcome at home and the relationship with the homeland fray at once, that question – which date matters more – feels less like an abstraction and more like the defining dilemma of this anniversary year.

The writer is the author of A Matter of Trust (2021) and Indian Genius (2024).